

If governance was something like a relay race, it is time the UPA Government started worrying about the last lap. This is the sixth Mood of the Nation poll conducted by INDIA TODAY since Manmohan Singh took over as the prime minister in 2004. In our last poll conducted halfway through his government's tenure, Manmohan was able to achieve something that eluded even the most popular of his predecessors—bucking the anti-incumbency trend. But as the major participants start preparations for the battle, which must be held by May next year but could possibly be held earlier, our poll shows an unrelenting string of bad news for the Government. Around this time last year, the ruling UPA's vote share was seven percentage points more than the Opposition NDA's. It has now shrunk to three. A general election held a year ago would have seen the treasury benches outnumbering the Opposition by over a 100 seats. This poll shows the UPA is poorer by about 50 seats.

Manmohan, of course, can draw some solace from the

fact that his personal rating, at 15 per cent, is his highest ever, though it is lower than the lowest ratings of all previous prime ministers, except during the United Front interregnum. But consider the flip side: the rating of Sonia Gandhi, the chairperson and guiding spirit of UPA, at 16 per cent is at its lowest ever, a full nine percentage points below Atal Bihari Vajpayee, who two months after announcing his retirement from active politics, seems to be the leader that India wants at its helm. The poll throws up some interesting snippets. BJP attracts more young voters; BSP is now the third largest party, eclipsing the Left and some regional parties whose fortunes have dipped; despite all the hype about the common minimum programme, only 28 per cent feel it is beneficial for the common man; and more than a year after her last film release and now happily married, Aishwarya Rai stays perched as the top heroine, while the top two slots among male actors are shared by her father-in-law and husband, in that order. **by Ashok K. Damodaran**

If polls were held today, who would you vote for?

CONGRESS+

RJD, NCP, JMM, LJP, DMK, MDMK, KEC(M), IUML, RPI, PMK, FBL, TRC and the Left, except in Kerala and West Bengal.

January 2008

236-245

38.6%

	Seats	Vote%
February 2007	263-273	40.2
August 2006	252-261	39.3
January 2006	232-242	38.3
Actuals 2004	234	37.8

Swing  **0.8**

BJP+

JD(U), SHIV SENA, BIJU JANATA DAL, SHIROMANI AKALI DAL AND TRINAMUL CONGRESS

January 2008

176-185

35.4%

	Seats	Vote%
February 2007	150-160	33.9
August 2006	152-161	33.6
January 2006	170-180	33.8
Actuals 2004	184	33.5

Swing  **1.9**

OTHERS+

AIADMK, SP, BSP, INLD, AGP AND THE LEFT PARTIES IN KERALA AND WEST BENGAL

January 2008

116-126

26%

	Seats	Vote%
February 2007	115-116	25.9
August 2006	125-134	27.2
January 2006	125-135	27.9
Actuals 2004	125	28.7

Swing  **-2.7**

The percentage swing is the change in vote share reflected in the Mood of the Nation Poll in January 2008 compared to the actual vote share in the Lok Sabha elections held in May 2004.

Best party to solve the problems of the country



All figures in per cent
Rest: Don't know/Can't say

Which party is more concerned about the poor?



All figures in per cent
Rest: Don't know/Can't say

Which party is best capable of giving a stable government?



All figures in per cent
Rest: Don't know/Can't say